



CSS selectors 10m

A CSS selector specifies which HTML element is styled according to the rules in the related declaration block. It's like a sign pointing out to the browser which elements within the HTML file the declaration block (rules) will apply to.

Remember, the selector is the CSS code that appears before the curly brackets { }. The curly brackets define the declaration block.

You can combine multiple selectors and multiple elements in your CSS code to create complex styling rules. Where similar rules apply to many elements, selectors should be grouped to keep your CSS code tidy and easier to read.

CSS selectors can be grouped into five categories:

CSS selector category	Use	CSS syntax	Example

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Simple selectors	Selects elements according to name, id and class. Includes the universal selector (selects all elements on the page using the * symbol). Includes the grouping selector (ability to apply the same style to a group of elements by separating each selector with a comma).	element_name { property:property value }	p { text-align: center; color: blue; } All elements on the page will be centre-aligned, with a blue text colour.
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Combinator selectors	Selects elements according to a specific relationship between them. There are four different combinators in CSS: descendant selector (space) child selector (>) adjacent sibling selector (+) general sibling selector (~).	Descendant selector: selector1 selector2 { property:property value } Child selector: selector1 > selector2 { property:property value } Adjacent sibling selector: former_element + target_element { property:property value } General sibling selector: former_element ~ target_element { property:property value }	Descendant selector: div p { text-align: center; color: blue; } Applies this style to the elements within the element. Child selector: div > p { text-align: center; color: blue; } Applies this style to the elements that are children of the element (that is, directly below the element in the DOM).
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Pseudo-class selectors	Selects an element based on a specific state. For example, you can style elements so that when a user hovers their mouse over it, it changes colour. Or you can style a link differently depending on whether the link has been visited or not.	<pre>selector:pseudo-class { property:property value; }</pre>	<pre>a:hover { background-color: red; }</pre> Applies a red background colour to a link when hovered over.
Pseudo-element selectors	Used to style specific parts of an element. For example, you can use this to style the first line of a paragraph element. Selects elements based on the presence or value of a specific attribute.	<pre>selector::pseudo-element { property:property value; }</pre>	<pre>p::first-line { color: red; font-style: italic; }</pre> First line of paragraph will be formatted as font colour red and in italics.
Attribute selectors		<pre>selector[attribute] { property:propertyvalue; }</pre>	<pre>a[title] { color: purple; }</pre> Applies the colour purple to the title attributes.

Dig deeper

To learn more about CSS selectors, read these resources, which demonstrate how CSS selectors can be used to select and style elements:

- MDN web docs page on *CSS Selectors*
- W3Schools page on *CSS Selectors*.

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You will learn how to apply different types of selectors in the following sections.

The next section will demonstrate how to apply CSS to HTML.



Thoughts on this page?

